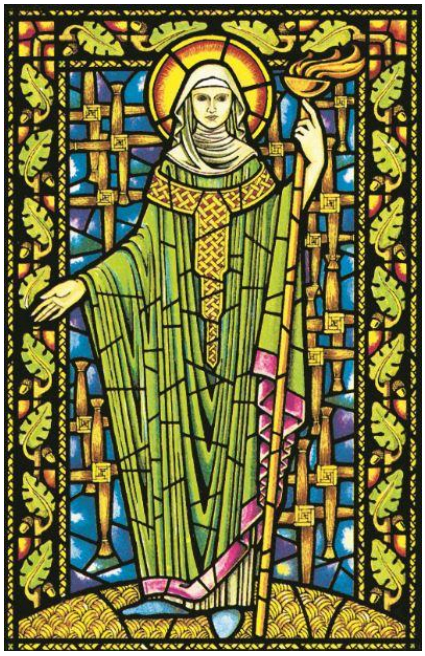
First Congregational Church of Los Angeles
Fall Series 8
Sacred Earth, Sacred Soul ~ The Sacred Feminine
25 October 2026



Mary of the Gael Stained Glass ~ From Saint Brigid of Kildare School

COMMUNION
Update LVF 19 October
Preaching: ML
Worship Leading: LVF and Cynthia Siadat

Organ Prelude-Concert

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Chiming of the Hour

[Laura & Cynthia to center chancel]

Welcome **LVF**

Words of Gathering **CS & LVF**
CS: In the midst of wind and fire,
rain and thunderclaps,
mist and darkness,
we feel our hearts opening.

LVF: Softened by the turbulent powers,

like hard earth now turning easily
on the blade of a plow,
hope sows itself into our heart's deep crevices.

CS: There it remains, nurtured in some mysterious
way ready to burst forth
into some long-distant, shadowed day.

LVF: If it be fear that opens us to hope,
then fill us with it!

CS: If it be love that sows it in our hearts,
then let us feel love's drenching presence!

LVF: If it be faith that nurtures seeds already sown,
then give us strength to wait the day
when faith is all we have and all we need!

O Holy Moment,
in the places where we live our lives and find meaning,
plant within each one of us, seeds with endless hearts,
as you ground us in your presence and call us to grow.
[gv/adaptedlvf]

CS: May it be so.
May it be so for us!

LVF: ***Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering***

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn Of Gathering** ***To You, O God, All Creatures Sing LASST UNS ERFREUEN
To you, O God, all creatures sing, and all creation, everything
sings your praises, alleluia!
Your burning sun with golden beam, your silver moon with softer gleam
sing your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your wind that blows the tempest by,
your clouds that's sail across the sky
sing your praises, alleluia!
Your morning rises with a song,
and lights of evening sing along,
sing your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

Your flowing waters, crystal clear,
make melodies for you to hear,

sings your praises, alleluia!
Your fire,…bountiful and bright,
remembering your warmth and light,
sing your praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

To you, O God, day after day,
your planet earth in every way,
sing your praises, alleluia!
As savory fruit and fragrant flower
show forth your glory and your power,
singing praises, alleluia,
alleluia, alleluia, alleluia.

-text adapted by Miriam Therese Winter

[Laura to center chancel]

Prayer of Awareness **LVF**

Christ, our Light,
with every morning
you welcome us in the world,
and with your lavish care
you meet our hunger and thirst.

On this day, help us sense the feast
you have placed within this hour -
on this hallowed, holy,
blessed day.

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

[All turn towards choir]

Introit The Joys of Life Esme Gregoropoulos

The Cathedral Ringers, Grace Sheldon-Williams, *Conductor*

[Cynthia to lectern]

***The Lord's Prayer** **CS**

In this place, we celebrate the mystery of who God is, and remember that our tradition is rich in calling the Divine by many names: Amma, Abba, Loving Mother, Compassionate Father, Source of Life, Sacred Presence.
Because of this Mystery, we invite you to address the Holy as you feel led, as we share together this Womanist Lord's Prayer…

Our [Mother],
who is in heaven with us,
we call upon your names.
Your wisdom come.
Your will be done,
in all the spaces in which you dwell.
Give us each day
sustenance and perseverance.
Remind us of our limits as
we give grace to the limits of others.
Separate us from the temptation of empire,
and deliver us into community.
For you are the dwelling place within us,
the empowerment around us,
and the celebration among us,
now and forever. Amen. [Grace Cathedral, Womanist Lord's Prayer Beyoncé Mass]

[All turn towards altar]

***Gloria Deo**
Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

[Laura center chancel]

***Passing of the Peace** **LVF**
As we share this ancient greeting,
we invite you to offer signs of peace to one another with a bow
- a gesture used broadly across many cultures
as a sign of greeting, respect, honor, humility, and love.
This morning, may it be an expression
of the intention of the peace with which we long to live
with one another, the world, and all creation.

When the path is simple, peace.
When the way is complicated, peace.
May Christ not only show us the way
but also be the way we travel:
way of blessing, way of peace.
[Jan Richardson - *The Sanctuary of Women*]

This morning, may the peace of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

[Cynthia & LVF to lectern]

Reading from Our Religious Tradition ***from the Wisdom of Sirach*** **LVF & CS**
CS: Listen now to these words from the apocryphal book, Sirach.

LVF: Hear Wisdom sing her own praises;
she proudly proclaims her glory among her own people.
She speaks out in the assembly of YHWH, in the presence of God's host:
"I am the word come forth from the mouth of YHWH; I enveloped the earth like a mist.
I dwelt in the high heavens, my judgment seat a cumulus cloud.
Alone I encompassed the vault of the sky; I wandered across the abyss.
Over the waves of the sea, over the whole earth, over all peoples and nations I reigned.
I searched for a place to rest among all these places, where I would dwell among all of creation.
I have put down roots among an honored people, selected to be God's portion.

CS: "Come near, all you who yearn to eat heartily of my fruit; you will be reminded
that I am sweeter than honey, more precious than the honeycomb.
Once you feed on me, you'll yearn for more; once you drink of me, you'll thirst for more.
Once you hear me out, you are beyond disgrace; once you follow my regimen,
you'll fail no more. All this is the book of the Covenant of YHWH,
the Law which Moses ordained for us, as the heritage for the assemblage of Jacob.
It floods with wisdom like the Pishon, like the Tigris during the fruiting season;
it overflows with understanding, like the Euphrates, like the Jordan at harvest time;
it flows with discipline, like the Nile, like the Gihon when the grapes are ripe.

LVF: Our ancestors never fully understood its message, our contemporaries still lack a full grasp. Its thoughts are wider than the oceans, its ambition deeper than the abyss.
"And I, I was like a stream branching off a river, like a waterway running through a field.
I said, 'I will water my garden, soak my flower beds.' And behold!
My waterway became a stream and my stream became a river.

CS: Once again I will send forth my teachings, shining like the dawn,
that its light may be viewed far and wide. I will send forth my teaching like prophecy
and will it to future generations. Let it be known that I have not toiled just for myself,
but for all who thirst for wisdom.

LVF: This is the witness of the ancients…
Thanks be to God!

[Christoph transition Michael to center chancel]
Prayers with the People **ML**

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Each week during our time together, we invite you to use this time for reflection and prayer.

In these moments as we turn to the Holy One,
may the ebb and flow of our thinking
settle into stillness.
May each heaviness we carry
be released into the Divine love.
May the rhythm of our breathing
restore a spaciousness within.
May we listen gently enough
to feel the wonder and mystery of God's presence.

Silence

[Christoph transition out of silence]

Prayer of our Hearts

For the wisdom that fashioned the universe
and can be read in the earth's dark depths
and in heaven's infinity of lights,
Thanks be to you, O God.

For the wisdom of teachers before us
and their words and imaginative seeing,
for the wisdom of those we have known
and their silence and humility of speech,
and for wisdom's wellspring in my own soul
and in the soul of every human being
from which ancient truths and new realizations spring forth,
Thanks be to you.

Let wisdom unfold in our hearts and minds
and in the people of every nation.
Let us see the foundations for a new harmony
within us and between us,
the foundations for a recovered unity
with the earth and all of its life-forms,
for the ground of life which is in you, O God,
for the ground of all life, which is in you.

In the silence of our hearts
let us give thanks for the gift of this day
as we pray for the life of the world…

In the great light that rules the day
and in the gentler light that guides the night,
may we glimpse the shinings of your presence, O God,
may we glimpse the shinings of your presence.
Amen and Amen.

[Christoph transition for Laude]

Meditation Anthem The Gnomic Verses of Saint Kassía

Text and Music:Kassía (9th century)
Arranged by Ianthe Marini

Ianthe Marini, Tiffany Ho, Molly Pease, Rachel Steinke, *Quartet,* Dr. Christoph Bull, *Drone*
Wealth without friends is a dark dwelling place! I've no respect for a judge who shows favoritism to status and takes orders from influential individuals. Wealth covers sin. The poor are left naked. The greedy hoarder of wealth lives in poverty in the midst of wealth; they possess all things except those they do not know how to use.

[Christoph transition Michael to pulpit]

Sermon ***The Sacred Feminine*** **ML**

[Christoph transition as Michael & Laura go behind communion table]

The Eucharist and Blessings **LVF & ML**

Words of Invitation and Remembrance
At this table, we bless and are blessed by these elements:
the bread and the fruit of the vine are gifts of the Earth,
they are gifts of God.

In the sharing of this holy meal,
may they become for us sacred reminders
of all that has been offered in this unfolding story,
all the sacrifices necessary to give us life,
to shape and animate our bodies, our minds, and our hearts.

In sharing this meal, we enter into a new covenant, with you,
with all creation, and with one another.
We promise to walk gently on this planet,
to give voice to those who have no voice,
to listen with our hearts,
to love kindness,
and to seek peace.

We break this bread as Jesus broke it.
We pour this cup as Jesus poured it.

And we remember that our lives are changed
each time we come together and share
the bread and the cup.

You are welcome at this table if you have a little faith, a lot of faith, absolutely no faith, or are of another faith. This is the Table of the Christ, and the welcome is wide!

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup
At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

[Cynthia to lectern]

Invitation to Generosity **CS**

Each Sunday we invite you to join our staff and leadership as contributors to First Church. We are all grateful to be together each week, here in the Cathedral and online. In your programs, you will find a QR Code. Simply hold your camera up to the code and you'll be directed to our giving page. If you'd like to access the website from a browser, you can do so at fccla.org/give. Or, if you brought an offering with you today, baskets will be passed by our Hospitality Team. Please know, we are so grateful for your commitment to First Church.

Listen now to these words from Jan Richardson as our invitation to offering today.

May the God who dwells behind time
and the God who dwells within time
bless us with the gift of time.
May it be for us an open door,
a spacious place,
a realm of meeting,
a world of grace.

May the power of Brigid inspire us,
the grace of Brigid attend us
the flame of Brigid engage us.
And may the God who provided her
all these gifts
provide them also to us,
that we may go into the world
with her lavish generosity
and her creative fire.
[Jan Richardson]

Thank you for your ongoing generosity through the resources, time, and talents you bring to strengthen our community to be the Love of the Divine in the world.

Offertory Vuelie — Fjellheim & Beck
Indigenous Sámi Yoik

Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[All turn towards altar]

***Doxology**
From all that dwell below the skies,
let the Creator's praise arise!
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Your name shall sound and praises soar
till suns shall rise and set no more.
Alleluia! Alleluia!
Alleluia! Alleluia! Alleluia!
[adapt/Isaac Watts, 1719]

[Cynthia to lectern]

***Prayer of Offering** **CS**
Please join me now in this Prayer of Offering…
Thank you, Good God,
for all the gifts we have already received
from your marvelous gifts of creation,
and our time together on this day.
As we give these offerings,
we ask for help in using them wisely
and in ways that will help us,
bring life to all your children
as we honor your dream for creation,
more deeply.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

[Michael and Laura center chancel]

Life at First Church **LVF & ML**
-Fall Festival outside in the Forecourt immediately following our service today!

-All Saint's Service of Remembrance next Sunday. Bring small mementos and pictures for Table. Cathedral Choir will present a unique program entitled, *Becoming Earth.*
-Resonance Collective tonight

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Words of Blessing **ML**

May the spirit of Saint Brigid,
woman of lavish hospitality,
inspire you this day.

Amid the fragments,
may you find the wild bounty
and in every moment, a feast.

Before you, behind you,
may Christ our light
attend your way.

May it ever be so.
May it ever be so for all of us!

Choral Response The Song of Brigid Laura Ash
Cathedral Choir, Dr. Ianthe Marini, *Conductor*

[Choir mics on for hymn leaders]

Hymn for the Journey** ***Holy Wisdom SALVE REGINA COELITUM

Who comes from God, as Word and Breath? Holy Wisdom.
Who holds the keys of life and death? Mighty Wisdom.
Crafter and Creator too, Eldest, she makes all things new;
Wisdom guides what God would do, Wisest One, Radiant One,
welcome, Holy Wisdom.

Who lifts her voice for all to hear? Joyful Wisdom.
Who shapes a thought and makes it clear? Truthful Wisdom.
Teacher, drawing out our best, magnifies what we invest,
names our truth, directs our quest. Wisest One, Radiant One,
welcome, Holy Wisdom.

Whom should we seek with all our heart? Loving Wisdom.
Who, once revealed, will not depart? Faithful Wisdom.
Partner, Counselor, Comforter, love has found none lovelier,
life is gladness lived with her. Wisest One, Radiant One,
welcome, Holy Wisdom.

[Laura center chancel]

Postlude

Dr. Christoph Bull, *Organist-in-Residence*

Inside The Music - Dr. Ianthe Marini

The musical exploration of the day celebrates the Divine Feminine in each of us. We begin with a song of exhilaration composed for bells by one of our beloved youth, Esme Gregoropoulos. In this exclamation we express that the Divine Feminine is loud and boisterous and filled with unabashed Joy!

In meditation, we center the work of 9th century Greek nun, poet, composer, and political and religious dissident, Saint Kassiani. Her musical works are considered the first historical record of documented music composed by a female, and her poetry some of the earliest examples of feminism: fighting totalitarian imperial power, and publicly defending the agency, intellectual capacity, and dignity of women. A woman of wealth and education, Kassia fiercely defended and funded the impoverished and the imprisoned, using her private wealth to fund the underground religious resistance movement in opposition to the policies of the Byzantine Empire before relinquishing her wealth to become a nun, founding a convent of her own. A staunch dissident of the patriarchal systems of power, her writing was rooted in her fierce criticism of the systemic hypocrisy of Empire and Religion. She famously stated, "*I hate silence when it is time to speak",* and through her gnomic verses we celebrate that the Divine Feminine is opinionated and outspoken, standing up to and speaking out against oppressive systems of patriarchy and capitalism.

In offertory, we sing the Yoik musical tradition of the Indigenous Sámi people of Sápmi, spanning modern day Scandinavia. One of the oldest musical traditions in Europe, yoiking was banned by Lutheran policy from the 17th to 20th centuries, condemned as sinful and demonic. In resistance, groups of Sámi women preserved the tradition through private ceremony and familial agency, leading to a cultural resurgence of the tradition in the 1970s and the passing of legal cultural protections for the Sámi people. This particular yolk is heard in the *Frozen* movies and serves as the musical connection of Elsa and Anna to their mother and her Indigenous roots. Through the singing of Yoik, we assert the dignity and the insistence of the Divine Feminine in her relationship to the sacred earth and her sacred culture, and her brave commitment to defying its erasure by religious and political systems.

And finally in choral response, we sing the Song of Brigid in celebration of Saint Brigid of Kildare, 5th century Irish activist who created a monastery city system that welcomed all and provided legal protection, shelter, and health care for the imprisoned, the sick, the impoverished, the orphan, and those who had been ousted by patriarchal religious systems. This monastery

flourished into a thriving self-governing urban center, becoming the first *Sanctuary City*. In our singing of Saint Brigid, we affirm that the Divine Feminine uses her intellect and civic organization in the work of radical acceptance.